

Image-Ination

User Guide

Version 4.9

Tools, filters, brush tips and keyboard shortcuts

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1. Getting started

Image-Ination is a layered image editor for painting, photo touch-ups and game art. This guide covers the basics of every tool and filter. Press **F1** in the app at any time for the full list of shortcuts, and hover over any tool button to see a quick tip.

The window

- **Toolbox (left):** tools grouped into View, Select, Paint, Retouch, Shapes and Other. Below them, the **Paint studio** button (or **F7**) opens the traditional painting tools.
- **Tool options:** the settings for the current tool. Scrolling over this panel scrolls it and never changes a value by accident. Hold **Ctrl** while scrolling to change a value with the wheel.
- **Canvas (center):** each image opens in its own tab, with its own zoom, selection and undo history.
- **Panels (right):** Colors and palette, Navigator, Layers and History.

Opening and saving

- **Open** (Ctrl+O) reads PNG, JPEG, WebP, TIFF, BMP, GIF, TGA, ICO, DDS and more, plus GIMP **.xcf**, Photoshop **.psd**, OpenRaster **.ora** and Image-Ination projects. You can also drag files onto the window.
- **Save** (Ctrl+S) keeps everything (layers, masks, editable text) in an Image-Ination project (**.imin**). **Save as** can also write layered XCF, PSD or ORA.
- **Export as** (Ctrl+Shift+E) writes a flat image such as PNG or JPEG for sharing.
- **Autosave:** changed images are backed up every 5 minutes. If the app closes unexpectedly, it offers to restore them next time. You can change the interval in *Edit* ▸ *Preferences*.
- **Undo / redo:** Ctrl+Z and Ctrl+Y. The History panel lets you jump back to any step.

Moving around

- Mouse wheel zooms; Shift+wheel scrolls sideways.
- Hold **Space** or drag with the middle button to pan with any tool.
- **Ctrl+0** fits the image in the window, **Ctrl+1** shows actual pixels (100%).
- Click or drag in the Navigator panel to jump to part of the image.

Colors

- You paint with the **foreground** color. Some tools (two-color paint, gradients, the eraser on a locked layer) also use the **background** color.
- **X** swaps them; **D** resets them to black and white.
- With most painting tools, **Alt-click** on the canvas picks a color.
- Click a palette swatch to use it. The palette can be extended, generated from the image, or loaded and saved as GIMP .gpl, Paint.NET .txt or .hex files.

2. Tools

Press a tool's key to switch to it. Keys shown with Shift use the same letter with Shift held.

View

Tool	Key	What it does
Hand	`H`	Drag to pan. Double-click to fit the image in the window.
Zoom	`Z`	Click to zoom in, Alt-click or right-click to zoom out, drag a box to zoom to it.

Select

Tool	Key	What it does
Move	`V`	Drag to move the layer, or just the selected pixels. Drag the yellow handles on the layer outline to resize. Alt-drag duplicates the selection. Arrow keys nudge 1 px (Shift: 10 px).
Free Transform	`Ctrl+T`	Move, resize, rotate and flip. Shift keeps proportions; Ctrl-drag a corner to distort or add perspective. Enter applies, Esc cancels.
Crop	`C`	Drag a crop box and adjust it. Enter or double-click crops.
Rect / Ellipse Select	`M / Shift+M`	Drag a rectangle or ellipse.
Lasso	`L`	Draw a freehand outline.
Polygon Lasso	`P`	Click points; double-click or Enter closes it. Backspace removes the last point.
Magic Wand	`W`	Click to select an area of similar color. *Tolerance* sets how similar.
Quick Select	`Q`	Paint over an area and the selection grows to match its colors.

For every selection tool: **Shift** adds, **Ctrl** subtracts, **Ctrl+Shift** intersects and **Alt** draws from the center. Drag inside a selection to move its outline. Ctrl+A selects all, Ctrl+D deselects, Ctrl+I inverts.

Paint

Tool	Key	What it does
Brush	`B`	Soft or hard painting with any brush tip. Shift-click draws a straight line from the last stroke.
Pencil	`N`	Hard-edged pixels, ideal for pixel art. *Pixel-perfect* removes doubled corners.
Airbrush	`A`	Keeps building up paint while you hold the button.
Shade Brush	`Shift+H`	Paints rounded strokes lit from one side (see section 4).
Texture Brush	`Shift+T`	Paints a blend of several colors as a texture (see section 4).
Eraser	`E`	Erases to transparency. On a lock-alpha layer it paints the background color.
Background Eraser	`Shift+B`	Erases only colors similar to the one under the brush center.
Magic Eraser	`Shift+W`	Click to erase an area of similar color.
Paint Bucket	`G`	Fills an area of similar color with the foreground, background or a pattern.
Gradient	`Shift+G`	Drag to draw a gradient: linear, radial and other shapes. Shift snaps to 45°.

Tool	Key	What it does
Text	T	Click to add text. Click an existing text layer to edit it again.

Retouch

Tool	Key	What it does
Clone Stamp	S	Alt-click to set a source, then paint to copy it somewhere else.
Pattern Stamp	Shift+S	Paints with a pattern (set one with *Edit* ▸ *Define pattern*).
Healing	J	Spot mode: paint over blemishes. Sourced mode: Alt-click a clean area first.
Smudge	F	Drags color along the stroke, like a finger in wet paint.
Blur / Sharpen	R	Blurs or sharpens where you paint.
Dodge / Burn	0	Lightens (dodge), darkens (burn) or changes saturation (sponge) where you paint.
Color Replace	K	Replaces the color under the brush with the foreground color, keeping the shading.
Warp (Liquify)	Shift+F	Push, twirl, pinch or bloat pixels. *Reconstruct* undoes it locally.
Red Eye	Shift+J	Click a red pupil, or drag a box over the eye.

Shapes

Tool	Key	What it does
Line	Shift+L	Drag a line, optionally with arrowheads. Shift snaps to 45°.
Rectangle	Shift+R	Outline, filled, or both, with optional rounded corners. Shift makes a square.
Ellipse	Shift+E	Shift makes a circle; Alt draws from the center.
Polygon / Star	U	Drag from the center. Set the number of sides, or tick *Star*.

Other

Tool	Key	What it does
Eyedropper	I	Click picks the foreground color; Alt-click or right-click picks the background.
Ruler	Shift+I	Measures distance and angle. *Image* ▸ *Straighten* levels the image to the ruler line.
Mask: Hide	Y	Paints into the layer mask to hide parts of the layer (creates a mask if needed).
Mask: Reveal	Shift+Y	Paints into the layer mask to bring hidden parts back.

3. Brush options and brush tips

Every painting tool shares the same basic options, and most can use different brush tips from the right-click menu.

Common brush options

Option	What it does
Size	How big the brush is. **[** and **]** change it; so does Alt+wheel.
Hardness	Soft, feathered edge (low) to crisp edge (high). **{** and **}** change it.
Opacity	How see-through each stroke is. Keys **1** to **0** set 10% to 100%.
Flow	How much paint each stamp adds, so strokes build up as they overlap.
Spacing	Distance between stamps. Higher spacing turns shapes like stars into separate stamps.
Smoothing	Steadies shaky lines, at the cost of a slight lag.
Tip angle / Roundness	Rotates and flattens the tip, for calligraphic strokes.
Mode	The blend mode the paint uses, such as Multiply or Screen.
Symmetry	Mirrors what you paint horizontally, vertically or both.
Pen pressure	With a drawing tablet, pressure can control size and opacity.

Right-click a tool for brush tips

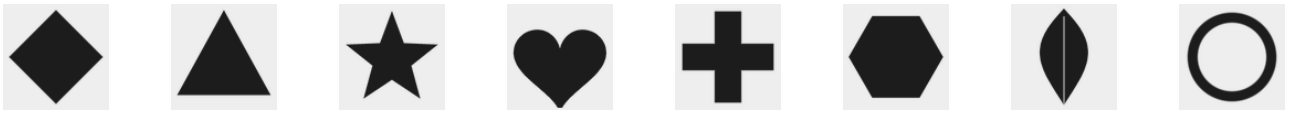
Right-click the **Brush, Pencil, Airbrush, Texture Brush, Eraser, Mask: Hide** or **Mask: Reveal** button in the toolbox. A menu opens with brush tips sorted into four groups, each with a preview. Picking a tip also sets a spacing that suits it, and the cursor shows the tip's real shape. The *Brush tip* list in the tool options does the same thing.

Basic — Everyday tips for general painting.



Round Square Fuzzy Calligraphic

Shapes — Stamp shapes along the stroke. Raise *Spacing* to separate them.



Diamond Triangle Star Heart Cross Hexagon Leaf Ring

Lines & patterns — Patterned marks for decoration, hatching and shading.



Wavy line Zigzag Hatching Dots

Textures — Natural media and effects. Each has several variations, so stamps don't repeat.



Stroke effects

The same right-click menu has a **Stroke effects** submenu (also in the tool options):

Effect	What it does
Wavy stroke	The line waves from side to side as you draw.
Scatter	Spreads the stamps out around the stroke, good for leaves, sparkles and splatter.
Size jitter	Varies the size of each stamp at random.
Tip rotation	*Fixed*, *Follow stroke* (leaves along a vine, bristles along the pull) or *Random*.
Reset effects	Turns all of the above off. *Reset to a round brush* also restores the round tip.

Tip: a square tip on the Pencil gives clean pixel-art squares. Effects work together with pen pressure, symmetry, roundness and angle.

4. Shade Brush and Texture Brush

Two special brushes that add form and texture as you paint.

Shade Brush (Shift+H)

Paints rounded strokes as if a light were shining on them: the side facing the light is lighter and the far side darker, so a stroke looks like a lit tube or form.

Option	What it does
Light direction	Where the light comes from. 135° is the top left.
Light height	Low light gives longer, more dramatic shading; high light is flatter.
Shading strength	How much lighter and darker the two sides get.
Shine	Adds a glossy highlight.
Light / shadow colors	Plain lighter/darker, warm light with cool shadow, cool light with warm shadow, or the background color as the light.

Texture Brush (Shift+T)

Paints with a set of colors blended into a natural texture, for foliage, stone, wood, fur, skin or marble. The texture continues seamlessly across strokes.

Option	What it does
Colors	Build the color set: **+ FG** adds the foreground color, click a swatch to change it, right-click one to remove it, or Shift-click palette swatches. **Shades** fills the set with variations of the foreground color, which is also what an empty set paints.
Texture	*Mottled*, *Speckled*, *Streaky* (follows the stroke, like wood grain), *Marbled*, or *Patches* (one color per dab, blending where dabs overlap).
Texture size	How large the patches of color are.
Blend between colors	Hard-edged patches (low) to smooth gradients (high).
Grain	Adds fine variation within each color.

The Texture Brush also works with every brush tip and stroke effect from the right-click menu.

5. Paint Studio

Click **Paint studio** below the toolbox, or press **F7**, to open tools that behave like real paint, in the style of a Bob Ross landscape.

Tool	Use it for
2" Background	Big criss-cross strokes for skies and water. Picks up and blends wet paint.
1" Landscape	Tap for leaves, bushes and clouds; pull for fields and banks.
Fan brush	Tap downward for evergreen trees, push up for grass and reeds.
Script liner	Long, thin, tapering lines for branches, twigs and signatures.
Filbert	Soft-edged shapes, petals and rocks.

Tool	Use it for
Round / Oval brush	Tap for small leaves, trees and bushes; pull for detail and trunks.
Palette knife	Lays paint that catches only the high spots of the canvas, like snow on mountains.
Scraper	Scrapes wet paint off to reveal what's underneath, for paths and highlights.
Natural sponge	Dab for mottled foliage, rocks and texture.
Foam pad	Smooth, streak-free coverage for soft skies and gradients.
Paper towel	Dab or wipe to lift wet paint: soft clouds, mist, glow around a light.

- **Wet canvas:** brushes pick up the wet paint they touch, so colors blend as you paint. Untick it to paint as if on a dry canvas.
- **Paint amount:** a brush runs dry over a long stroke, ending in scratchy texture.
- **Load the brush with:** the foreground color, *two colors* (foreground on one side, background on the other, for dark-and-light foliage), or a *clean brush* that only blends.
- **Impasto:** paint has thickness that catches the light. It lives in an "impasto" layer clipped to your paint layer; lower its opacity to soften it, or click *Bake impasto into the layer* to merge it.
- **Action** (scraper, paper towel, foam pad, sponge): *Erase* lifts paint off with the tool's texture; *Smudge* pushes and blends wet paint. The foam pad and sponge can also *Paint*.
- Flat brushes turn to follow your stroke unless *Brush angle* is set to *Fixed*.

6. Layers

Layers stack like sheets of glass: what's on upper layers covers what's below.

- The **+** button in the Layers panel adds an empty layer; *Layer* ▸ *New layer...* (Ctrl+Shift+N) lets you set its name, fill, size, mode and opacity.
- **Right-click** a layer in the panel for properties, rename, duplicate, merge, masks and more.
- Each layer has a **blend mode** (29 to choose from) and an **opacity**.
- **Layers can extend past the canvas.** Anything you move off the edge is kept and comes back when you move it back. Imported images keep their full size. *Image* ▸ *Fit canvas to layers* grows the canvas to show everything.
- **Layer masks** hide parts of a layer without erasing them. Paint black (Mask: Hide) to hide and white (Mask: Reveal) to show. Press \ to view the mask.
- **Clipping mask** (Ctrl+Alt+G) shows a layer only where the layer below has pixels.
- **Lock transparency** (/) lets you paint only over existing pixels.
- **Layer styles** (*Layer* ▸ *Layer style*): drop, long and perspective shadow, outer glow, stroke and bevel & emboss.
- **Between tabs:** drag a layer from the Layers panel onto another tab to copy it there; hold **Shift** while dropping to move it instead. Dropping on an empty part of the tab bar makes a new image.

7. Adjustments and filters

Adjustments and filters apply to the current layer, or to the selection if there is one. Most open a dialog with a live preview. **Ctrl+F** repeats the last filter.

Adjustments menu

Adjustment	What it does
Brightness / contrast	Simple overall lightness and punch.
Levels (Ctrl+L)	Set the black point, white point and midtones.
Curves (Ctrl+M)	Precise tone control by bending a curve.
Exposure	Brighten or darken like a camera's exposure setting.
Hue / saturation (Ctrl+U)	Shift colors, and make them more vivid or more muted.
Vibrance	Boosts dull colors more than ones that are already vivid.
Color balance (Ctrl+B)	Tint the shadows, midtones and highlights separately.
Temperature / tint	Make the image warmer, cooler, greener or more magenta.
Photo filter	A colored lens filter effect.
Channel mixer	Rebuild each color channel from a mix of the others.
Black & white	Convert to grayscale with control over how each color converts.
Gradient map	Map the image's tones onto a foreground-to-background gradient.
Shadows / highlights	Lift dark areas and recover bright ones.
Invert	Turns the image into its negative.

Adjustment	What it does
Desaturate (Ctrl+Shift+U)	Removes color.
Auto contrast / Auto color	One-click fixes for flat or color-cast photos.
Equalize	Spreads tones evenly for maximum contrast.
Sepia	An old-photo brown tone.
Threshold	Pure black and white at a cut-off point.
Posterize	Reduces each channel to a few levels, for a poster look.
Reduce colors / dither	Limit the image to a small palette, with optional dithering.
Solarize	Inverts the brightest tones, a darkroom effect.
Color to alpha	Turns a chosen color (such as a white background) transparent.

Filters menu

Group	Filters
Blur	**Gaussian** (smooth), **Box**, **Motion** (movement in one direction), **Spin** and **Zoom** (radial), and **Surface** (smooths while keeping edges sharp).
Sharpen	**Sharpen**, **Unsharp mask** (controlled sharpening) and **High pass** (keeps only fine detail, for blending).
Noise	**Add noise** (film grain), **Median** (removes speckles) and **Dust & scratches**.
Edges	**Find edges**, **Sobel edges**, **Contour / trace** and **Emboss** (raised-relief look).
Distort	**Pinch**, **Twirl**, **Wave**, **Ripple**, **Spherize** (bulge), **Lens distortion** (barrel / pincushion) and **Polar coordinates**.
Stylize	**Pixelate** (big square blocks) and **Oil paint** (painterly brush look).
Light and Shadow	**Drop**, **long** and **perspective shadow** (each on a new layer), and **Vignette** (darkened edges).
Render	**Clouds** from the foreground and background colors, **Checkerboard** and **Grid lines**.
Texture & game art	**Make seamless** (tileable textures), **Generate normal map** (for 3D lighting), **Offset** (wrap around) and a **3 × 3 tile preview**.

Other handy menus

- **Edit:** Fill, Stroke selection, **Content-aware fill** (Shift+Backspace) removes a selected object and fills the gap from its surroundings, and Define pattern.
- **Select:** Color range, Grow, Shrink, Border, Smooth and Feather (Shift+F6).
- **Image:** Image size (Ctrl+Alt+I), Canvas size (Ctrl+Alt+C), rotate and flip, Straighten, Slice into frames/layers, Merge visible and Flatten.
- **File:** export layers as files, an animation (GIF / WebP / APNG) or a sprite sheet; export tiles; and **Batch process a folder** to convert many images at once.

8. Keyboard shortcuts

Tool keys are listed in section 2. Press **F1** in the app for the complete list.

Painting and view

Keys	Action
`[ ]`	Brush size smaller / bigger
`{ }`	Hardness down / up
`1 … 0`	Opacity 10% ... 100%
`Alt + wheel`	Brush size
`Alt-click`	Pick a color
`Shift-click`	Straight line from last point
`X`	Swap colors
`D`	Default colors
`F7`	Paint studio
`Right-click tool`	Brush tips and effects

Keys	Action
`Wheel`	Zoom
`Shift + wheel`	Scroll sideways
`Space-drag`	Pan
`Ctrl+= / Ctrl+-`	Zoom in / out
`Ctrl+0`	Fit in window
`Ctrl+1`	100%
`Ctrl+2`	200%
`Ctrl+'`	Pixel grid
`Ctrl+;`	Grid
`Ctrl+Shift+;`	Snap to grid
`Ctrl+H`	Selection edges
`Ctrl+Shift+H`	Layer outline
`F11`	Full screen

File and edit

Keys	Action
`Ctrl+N`	New image
`Ctrl+O`	Open
`Ctrl+Alt+O`	Open as layers
`Ctrl+Shift+I`	Import image as layer
`Ctrl+S`	Save
`Ctrl+Shift+S`	Save as
`Ctrl+Shift+E`	Export as
`Ctrl+W`	Close tab
`Ctrl+Tab`	Next tab
`Ctrl+Shift+Tab`	Previous tab
`Ctrl+Q`	Exit

Keys	Action
`Ctrl+Z`	Undo
`Ctrl+Y`	Redo
`Ctrl+X / C / V`	Cut / copy / paste as layer
`Ctrl+Shift+C`	Copy merged
`Ctrl+Shift+V`	Paste in place
`Ctrl+Alt+V`	Paste as new image
`Delete`	Clear
`Shift+F5`	Fill...
`Alt+Backspace`	Fill with foreground
`Ctrl+Backspace`	Fill with background
`Shift+Backspace`	Content-aware fill

Select, image and layers

Keys	Action	Keys	Action
`Ctrl+A`	Select all	`Ctrl+Shift+N`	New layer
`Ctrl+D`	Deselect	`Ctrl+J`	Layer via copy
`Ctrl+Shift+D`	Reselect	`Ctrl+Shift+J`	Layer via cut
`Ctrl+I`	Invert selection	`Ctrl+E`	Merge down
`Shift+F6`	Feather	`Ctrl+] / Ctrl+[`	Move layer up / down
`Enter / Esc`	Apply / cancel transform	`Ctrl+Shift+] / [`	Bring to front / back
`Arrows`	Nudge 1 px (Shift: 10 px)	`F2`	Layer properties
`Ctrl+Alt+I`	Image size	`/`	Lock transparency
`Ctrl+Alt+C`	Canvas size	`Ctrl+Alt+G`	Clipping mask
`F1`	Keyboard shortcuts	`\`	Show mask

Adjustments and filters

Keys	Action	Keys	Action
`Ctrl+L`	Levels	`Ctrl+Shift+B`	Auto color
`Ctrl+M`	Curves	`Alt+Ctrl+Shift+L`	Auto contrast
`Ctrl+U`	Hue / saturation	`Ctrl+Alt+Shift+B`	Black & white
`Ctrl+B`	Color balance	`Ctrl+F`	Repeat last filter
`Ctrl+Shift+U`	Desaturate	`Ctrl+Alt+Shift+E`	New layer from visible

9. Updates and help

- Image-Ination checks for updates automatically about once a day. When one is available it shows what's new and installs it for you. You can also use *Help* ▸ *Check for updates…*, or turn automatic checks off in *Edit* ▸ *Preferences*.
- Both the installed version and the zip (portable) version update themselves. The portable version keeps its settings in a **data** folder beside the app, so it can run from a USB stick.
- *Help* ▸ *License* shows the license and *Help* ▸ *Third-party notices* lists the open-source components the app uses.